Global Markets Research
2 June 2026

China factory automation data: May 2026

EQUITY: JAPAN MACHINERY

Research Analysts

Japan machinery

Boqiong Wang - NSC
boqiong.wang@nomura.com
+81 3 6703 1217

Angela Yang - NSC
wenching.yang@nomura.com
+81 3 6703 1819

Kentaro Maekawa - NSC
kentaro.maekawa@nomura.com
+81 3 6703 1208

Airtac sales up 26% y-y in May

Sector-specific movements due to seasonality; increased AI data center investment also likely to contribute

We estimate that Airtac daily sales were up 26% y-y and down 1% m-m in May

Taiwanese pneumatic equipment manufacturer Airtac [1590 TT], which generates around 90% of its sales in China, released May sales data on 2 June, with CNY-denominated sales up 26% and down 10% m-m (Figure 4). We estimate that daily sales were up 26% y-y and down 1% m-m (assuming 20.5 business days), broadly in line with April, the period that follows the Lunar New Year and is likely to represent the highest level of the year.

The company's comments did not include any major changes from the previous month, and were as follows: In May, sales and order value both rose y-y to record highs despite there being fewer business days owing to the long weekend in China, and May order value continued to exceed shipment value, with both orders and shipments exceeding guidance. All changes in input costs caused by geopolitical factors are within a manageable range for the company. Moreover, the 15th five-year plan put forward by the Chinese government emphasizes smart manufacturing and industrial advancements, and management expect both to contribute to increased demand in the pneumatic equipment market. The company expects the government to continue to announce support measures as needed, and it remains optimistic about demand in the pneumatic equipment industry in FY26 and the company's overall development.

By customer sector: Orders from electronics and battery industries correcting on seasonal factors since April, but orders from machine tool industry have been solid

In terms of sales by industry, we estimate that sales rose 12% y-y for electronics (26% sales weighting), rose 55% for batteries (18%), rose 15% for autos (9%), rose 20% for packaging machinery (8%), rose 35% for machine tools (8%), rose 35% for general machinery (5%), rose 46% for textile machinery (5%), and fell 5% for energy and lighting (solar-power related) (3%). Sales look to have fallen m-m from April, when growth was particularly strong for electronics and batteries, which we attribute in large part to seasonal factors. Machine tool orders look to have been solid, rising further from April, when they were at a high level. We think this was due in large part to increased investment in AI data centers. Orders also look to have risen m-m from the textile machinery, packaging machinery, and general machinery sectors. Demand in the automation industry as a whole looks to have been strong, with the exception of solar power-related industries, albeit with monthly fluctuations from sector to sector.

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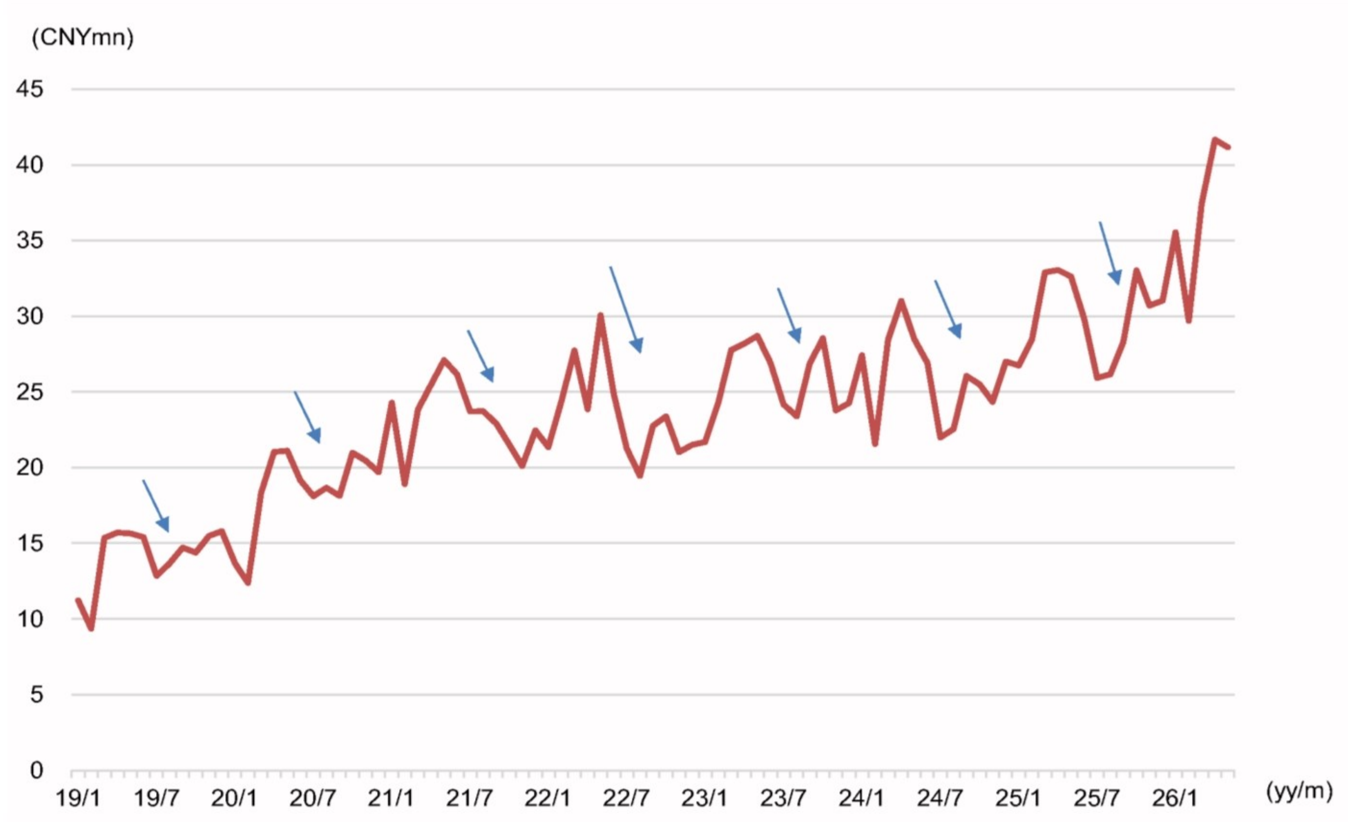
Reference figures

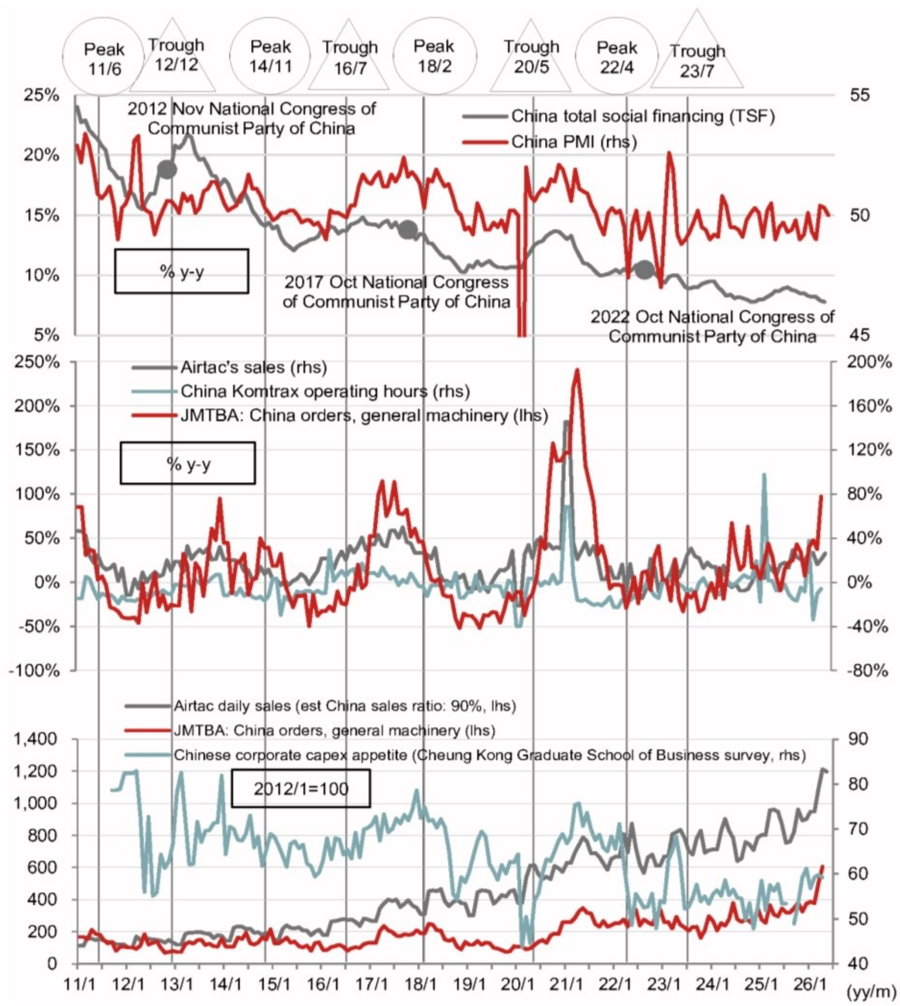
Fig. 1: Airtac daily sales

Sales tend to decline m-m in June and July owing to seasonality



Note: Daily sales = monthly sales ÷ number of business days.
Source: Nomura, based on company data

Fig. 2: China: Total social financing, Airtac sales, Komtrax operating hours, machine tool orders



Source: Nomura, based on People's Bank of China data, Cheung Kong Graduate School of Business data, data disclosed by each company, and Japan Machine Tool Builders' Association data

Fig. 3: Airtac's sales mix by user industry

Broad mix of customer industries, biggest is electronics

(%)	2022	2023	2024	2025
Electronics	25	22	29	27
Machinery	13	12	14	13
Batteries	17	14	8	14
Packaging	7	8	9	9
Autos	6	6	8	10
Energy and lighting	6	13	5	3
Other	26	25	27	24

Source: Nomura, based on company data

Fig. 4: China: Airtac sales, Komtrax operating hours, JMTBA machine tool orders for general machinery in China

Key data for considering machinery demand in China

	Airtac sales		Komtrax China		JMTBA: China orders, general machinery	
	(CNY '000)	(y-y)	(Hours)	(y-y)	(¥mn)	(y-y)
24/1	658,253	102%	80	88%	9,384	-1%
2	323,593	-39%	28	-62%	7,349	-18%
3	668,579	-4%	92	-11%	8,958	16%
4	698,022	15%	97	-4%	8,364	-19%
5	627,134	-1%	101	1%	9,852	15%
6	565,363	-4%	88	-3%	13,358	67%
7	549,841	-1%	88	-1%	9,795	34%
8	541,490	-7%	93	3%	9,199	14%
9	547,280	-7%	95	7%	9,744	20%
10	510,106	-6%	105	4%	9,369	63%
11	571,907	0%	105	4%	8,593	17%
12	621,207	11%	108	19%	12,320	18%
25/1	494,763	-25%	66	-18%	9,749	4%
2	526,614	63%	56	98%	9,017	23%
3	773,101	16%	94	2%	12,908	44%
4	776,591	11%	98	1%	10,809	29%
5	668,675	7%	93	-7%	10,401	6%
6	656,312	16%	81	-7%	12,112	-9%
7	648,335	18%	87	-2%	11,279	15%
8	615,003	14%	83	-11%	11,280	23%
9	707,606	29%	81	-15%	12,200	25%
10	627,824	23%	88	-17%	13,430	43%
11	690,959	21%	100	-5%	11,529	34%
12	744,836	20%	99	-8%	13,247	8%
26/1	817,845	65%	91	38%	13,655	40%
2	475,088	-10%	37	-34%	13,328	48%
3	899,165	16%	85	-10%	17,769	38%
4	937,464	21%	92	-6%	21,341	97%
5	843,421	26%				
23/1-2	860,331	3%	118	0%	18,378	3%
24/1-2	981,846	14%	108	-8%	16,733	-9%
25/1-2	1,021,377	4%	122	13%	18,766	12%
26/1-2	1,292,933	27%	128	5%	26,983	44%

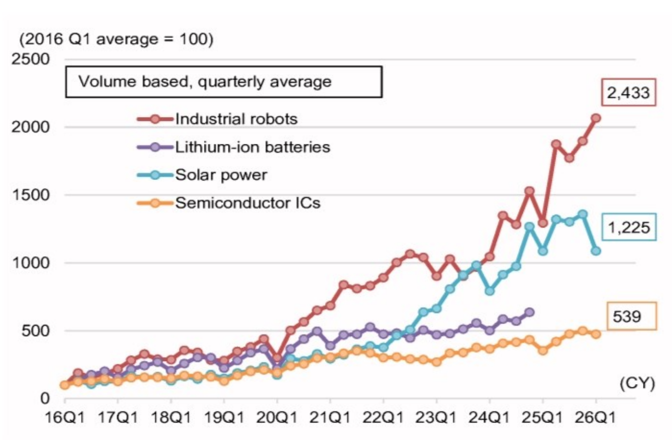
Source: Nomura, based on Japan Machine Tool Builders' Association and company data

Fig. 5: Timing of Chinese New Year

Year	Chinese New Year
11	3 Feb
12	23 Jan
13	10 Feb
14	31 Jan
15	19 Feb
16	8 Feb
17	28 Jan
18	16 Feb
19	5 Feb
20	25 Jan
21	12 Feb
22	1 Feb
23	22 Jan
24	10 Feb
25	29 Jan
26	17 Feb
27	6 Feb

Source: Nomura

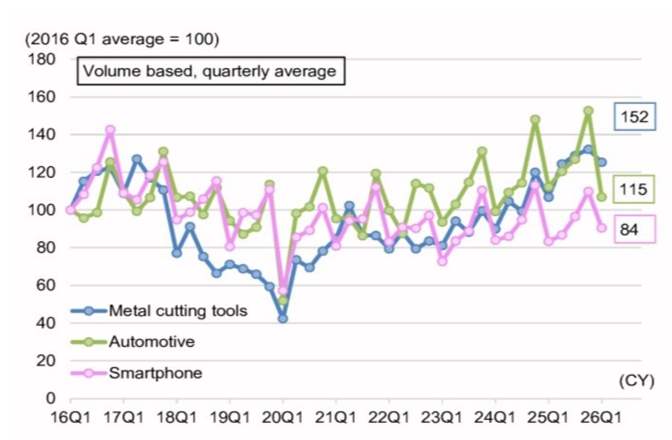
Fig. 6: Chinese industrial production: Growth areas



Note: Latest data is for 2026 Q1 (average of Jan, Feb and Mar). Figures inside boxes are most recent available monthly data (April). Figures for Li-ion batteries are through 2024 Q4.

Source: Nomura, based on CEIC (original data is from National Bureau of Statistics of China)

Fig. 7: Chinese industrial production: Cyclical areas



Note: Latest data is for 2026 Q1 (average of Jan, Feb and Mar). Figures inside boxes are most recent available monthly data (April).

Source: Nomura, based on CEIC (original data is from National Bureau of Statistics of China)

Appendix A-1

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